The UK Data Service: appropriate access

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Secure Data Access Manager

UK Data Service

Introduction:

- A short story
- Introducing the UK Data Service
- Types of data access
- Meeting demand
- Defining channels of access
- Rise of classification creep
- Why we should prevent this [got to be positive!]

Introducing the UK Data Service (1)

- "Delivering quality social and economic data resources”
- One service for data access in the UK
- Combines former services together:
  - Economic and Social Data Service
    - Longitudinal
    - International
    - Government
    - Qualidata
  - Secure Data Service
  - Census Support
- Service aimed at academia, non-profit and government

Types of data access

more control, more security, more detail

Source	Research data centres	Special licence	End user licence	Web dissemination
	All data, complete geographies	*Most data, limited geography, some recoding*	*Fewer variables, more recoding, NUTS1 only*	*Aggregate data only and Open*

fewer restrictions, easier access, less detail

From Ritchie, 2006

The costs of meeting demand (1)

Access	Acquisition	Ingest	Dissemination	Ongoing support	SDC
Open	Low	High	Low	Low	Nil
EUL	Med	Med	Low	Low	Nil
SL	Med	Med	Med	Med	Nil
Secure (remote)	High	High	High	High	Med
Secure (safe centre)	High	High	High	High	High

The costs of meeting demand (2)

- Our problem:
  - We have a pool of X data users
  - We cannot tell what their access needs are
  - How do we efficiently ‘sort’ these users?
- By maintaining levels of access to suit particular needs
- This leads to a pareto-efficient outcome

Meeting the challenge: achieving economies of scale

more control, more security, more detail

Source

Research data centres	Special licence	End user licence	Web dissemination
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Meeting the challenge: the results

- Researchers self-select
- The different channels provide required amount of support
- Pareto efficient
- Growth in demand encourages re-use of new sources
  - E.g. open access will create demand for secure versions

A short story

New challenges: classification creep

Classification creep

more control, more security, more detail

Source	Research data centres	Special licence	End user licence	Web dissemination
	All data, complete geographies + Special Licence + End User Licence	*Most data, limited geography, some recoding*	*Fewer variables, more recoding, NUTS1 only*	*Aggregate data only and Open*

fewer restrictions, easier access, less detail

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The rise of classification creep: consequences for access

- More restrictive access = fewer access requests
- Inequitable
- Loss of research to society, e.g. informing public policy, understanding society
- Continuing scarcity of quantitative researchers
- Less sensitive data made available through secure routes: e.g. aggregated geographies
  - Waste of resources
- Loss of pareto efficiency

The rise of classification creep: consequences for secure access

- Access channels are compliments, not substitutes
- Adverse selection will occur if channels are closed
  - Can all researchers become ‘trusted’?
  - Capture researchers for whom RDC access is unnecessarily burdensome
  - Attracting researchers who have an incentive to break rules
- Moral hazard
  - proliferation of data copying and unauthorised distribution
- Rising costs against falling budgets
- Unequal access –
  - we cannot support inexperienced researchers
- Fewer datasets available

Meeting the challenge of classification creep

- Combined data access prove that classification creep is unnecessary
- Indeed, it is dangerous: perverse effects of classification creep
- Secure options (e.g. remote, Safe Centre) become less safe
  - Researchers who previously experienced less restrictive access use these services, have to establish trusted researcher
  - Unless matched with funding, secure access cannot provide services that ensure security
- What can we do?